



The Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026

Keynote address

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Swachhata Knowledge Partner (SKP)

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CEPT University, Ahmedabad**

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Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026

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क्र.सं. 368(क).— इस अधिनियम प्रबंधन नियम, 2024 के प्रारूप वाली अधिसूचना जो की इस अधिनियम प्रबंधन नियम, 2018 को अधिकांश करेगी , भारत सरकार के पर्यावरण, वन और जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्रालय द्वारा, अधिसूचना संख्या मा.वा.नि 5369 (अ), तारीख 9 दिसंबर, 2024 के द्वारा भारत के राजपत्र, असाधारण भाग 2, खंड 3, उपखंड (ii) में प्रकाशित की गई थी, जिसमें इससे प्रभावित होने की संभावना वाले सभी व्यक्तियों से, उक्त अधिसूचना वाले राजपत्र की प्रतियाँ जनता को उपलब्ध कराए जाने की तारीख से साठ दिन की अवधि समाप्त होने से पूर्व, आपत्तियाँ और सुझाव आमंत्रित किए गए थे;

और, उक्त अधिसूचना वाले राजपत्र की प्रतियाँ जनता को 14 दिसंबर, 2024 को उपलब्ध बना दी गई थी;

और, उक्त अवधि के भीतर उक्त प्रारूप अधिसूचना के संबंध में जनता से प्राप्त आपत्तियों और सुझावों पर केंद्रीय सरकार द्वारा सम्यक् रूप से विचार किया गया है;

Key message

The SWM Rules 2026 shift cities

from "collect and dump“

to "segregate, process and recover.“

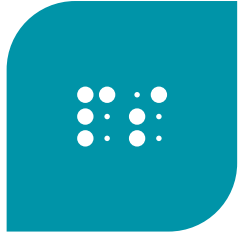
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Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026

Effective from April 1, 2026

Chapter	Chapter Summary
Chapter I	Establishes the scope, applicability and foundational definitions for a uniform solid waste management framework across urban and rural India.
Chapter II Environmentally sound management of solid waste	Creates a shared accountability framework by defining the roles of waste generators, BWGs, ULBs, processing facilities, State Governments and regulatory agencies across the waste value chain.
Chapter III Sanitary landfills	Prescribes technical standards and operational requirements to ensure environmentally sound collection, processing, resource recovery and disposal of solid waste.
Chapter IV Implementation Framework	Strengthens governance through digital monitoring, mandatory reporting, audits, environmental compensation and performance tracking mechanisms.
Chapter V Roles and Responsibilities	Establishes the duties across the three tier of governments, regulatory framework for authorisation, registration, inspections and enforcement to ensure compliance with SWM Rules 2026.

Five key focus area under Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026



**Mandatory
4-way
segregation**



**Stronger
accountability
of waste
generators**



**Extended
responsibility
for bulk waste
generators**



**Digital
tracking and
reporting**



**Environmental
compensation
for non-
compliance**

Shift in approach

Transforming urban waste management through segregation, circular economy, resource recovery, zero waste to landfill and accountability

SWM Rules 2016 vs. New SWM Rules 2026



2016 Rules = Urban waste management + basic segregation & processing

2026 Rules = All-India waste management + detailed segregation + recycling + energy recovery + strict compliance

Major Changes in SWM Rules 2016 vs. New SWM Rules 2026

	SWM Rule		New SWM Rule
 Scope and Applicability	Focused on urban areas, census towns, and notified regions within municipal boundaries.	➤	Expanded to cover urban and rural local bodies, SEZs, food parks, railways, airports, defense areas, etc..
 Waste Collection and Segregation	Segregation into three streams: biodegradable, non-biodegradable, and hazardous waste.	➤	Segregation into four streams: Wet, dry, sanitary, and special care waste.
 Bulk waste generator	Entities generating over 100 kg/day, including institutions, markets, and gated communities.	➤	Refined criteria, including floor area (20,000 sq. m.), water usage (40,000 liters/day), or waste generation (100 kg/ day)
 Decentralized Waste Processing	Encourages decentralized units for biodegradable waste.	➤	Mandates bulk waste generators to process waste locally or obtain EBWGR certificates.
 Waste Disposal	Promotes use of sanitary landfills for residual waste		Emphasizes use of advanced methods like Waste-to-Energy (WTE) and Refuse Derived Fuel (RDF).

Major Changes in SWM Rules 2016 vs. New SWM Rules 2026

	SWM Rule		New SWM Rule
 Monitoring and Reporting	Basic reporting to state authorities.	➤	2026 Introduces centralized online portals for quarterly and annual returns.
 Enforcement Mechanisms	Penalties and fines for non-compliance	➤	Stricter measures, including environmental compensation and annual environmental audits.
 Role of Producers (EPR)	Basic responsibility for managing packaging waste	➤	Stronger EPR: registration, targets, reporting, full lifecycle responsibility
 Public Awareness and Capacity Building	Focus on basic training for ULB personnel and public awareness.	➤	Comprehensive training, use of digital platforms, and integration of informal waste collectors.

Are we ready to declare our cities as SWM 2026 compliant city?

Can we demonstrate compliance with evidence?

Source



- **Lack of segregation at source**, manually segregation by ragpickers at dumpsite.
- **Limited Infrastructure** for segregation at city level.

Collection



- **Cities have sufficient infrastructure** for D2D collection.
- **Operational challenges** in management of D2D even faced by private operator.
- **Lack of accountability and monitoring** in D2D contracts

Waste Processing and Treatment



- Lack of processing infrastructure
- Few cities have MRF Centres and equipment for waste processing but **face operational challenges**.
- **Lack of capacity** of private operator.

Recycle/ Reuse



- **Presence of informal market** for selling waste to recyclers.
- Missing market for forward linkages
- **Plastic waste and C&D waste management** – lack of quantification and tracking.
- Only selected cities have functional C&D waste management sites and lack of demand of reusing the waste.

Household level 4-way Waste Segregation



Green Bin (Wet Waste):

Biodegradable, organic, kitchen, and food waste



Blue Bin (Dry Waste):

Recyclable materials. This includes plastics, paper, cardboard, glass, and metals.



Red Bin (Sanitary Waste):

used diapers, sanitary napkins/pads



Black Bin (Special Care/Hazardous Waste):

For e.g. paint cans, batteries, CFL bulbs, expired medicines

Actions for ULBs: "No segregation, no sustainable waste management."

Collection systems, vehicles, transfer stations and processing facilities must support four-stream segregation. It has to be supported through extensive IEC campaigns and facilitation

Bulk Waste Generators



This is an AI generated Image for reference.

Any entity meeting one of the following:

- Built-up area $\geq$ **20,000 sq. m.**
- Water consumption $\geq$ **40,000 L/day**
- Waste generation $\geq$ **100 kg/day**

Examples: Large residential societies, Universities, Government complexes, Malls, Hotels, Hospitals and institutions

Key Responsibilities of BWG's

- On-site waste processing
- Segregated collection and storage.
- Procure EBWGR Certificates if unable to process waste.

Actions for ULBs

- Identify Bulk waste generators
- Necessary directives to initiate managing on-site waste processing
- Levy user charges as per the prevailing norms

Moving from linear to circular economy

Cities concentrate waste generation, infrastructure, markets, and labour—making them ideal laboratories for circular solutions.

The circular economy has emerged as a promising approach to transform the linear "take-make-dispose" model into a more sustainable and efficient system.

Dimension	Key Benefits
Environment	Reduced waste, pollution, and land degradation
Climate	Lower GHG emissions, methane avoidance
Economy	Value creation, resource efficiency
Urban Finance	Lower SWM costs, new revenue streams
Jobs & Livelihoods	More jobs, informal sector inclusion
Public Health	Cleaner cities, safer workers
Resilience	Reduced material dependence, local supply chains



SBM focused on concept of 3R (Reduce, Reuse, Recycle), now evolving to 7R for urban India stimulating circular economy

- To ensure maximum resource recovery by converting waste to wealth, entire India is echoing the concept of 3R promoting circular economy for reduce, reuse and recycle.
- The theme of **Swachh Survekshan** (world's largest urban cleanliness survey) is **RRR (Reduce-Reuse-Recycle)**
- Under the campaign “**Meri LiFE, Mera Swachh Seher**” thousands of **RRR (Reduce-Reuse-Recycle)** centres have been set up in India
- Encouraging community participation as citizens **contribute** their clothes, shoes, old books, toys and used plastic to be reused or recycled.
- Other than RRR centers, there are **other unique RRR initiatives** such as making murals, artefacts and reusable products, generating energy etc **engaging local governments, Self help group, private organizations etc.**

With SBM Rules 2026, cities should move towards

7R: Systemic Circularity

Rethink – Refuse – Reduce – Reuse – Repair – Repurpose – Recycle



Need for exploring innovations - IoT and digital analytics for improving SWM



Machine based automated segregation of mixed waste



Monitoring of Garbage Vulnerable points through computer vision analytics using CCTVs/ DashCams



SMART bins – bin overflow monitoring through computer vision analytics

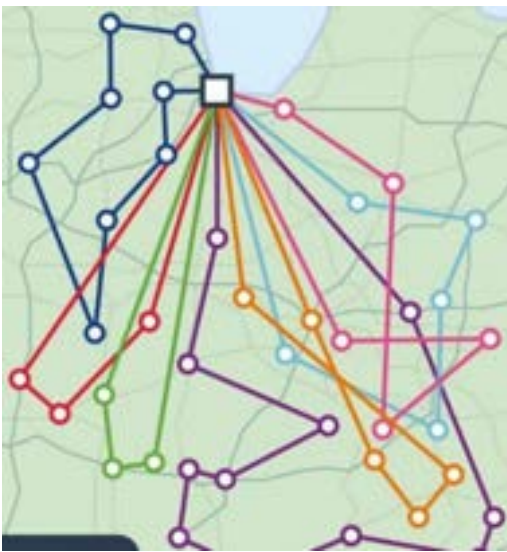


Drone based analytics for monitoring garbage hotspots



Riverbank waste monitoring

Garbage hotspot tracking



Route optimization for door-to-door collection through



Sensor based sewer monitoring for blockages and overflow

Restrictions on Landfilling and Remediation of Legacy Waste Dumpsites

- Restrictions on landfilling and address the remediation of legacy waste dumpsites.
- Landfills have been strictly restricted to **non-recyclable, non-energy recoverable waste and inert material**.
- **Higher landfill fees have been prescribed for local bodies for sending unsegregated waste to sanitary landfills. The landfill fee for unsegregated waste will be higher than the cost of segregation, transportation and processing of segregated waste.**
- Mandate **annual audits of landfills** by State Pollution Control Boards, with landfill performance to be overseen by District Collectors.
- Mandate **mapping and assessment of all legacy waste dumpsites** and provide for **time-bound biomining and bioremediation**, with quarterly progress reporting through the online portal.

Key provisions – Reporting, monitoring and compliance

- Development of a **Centralised Online Portal** to track all stages of solid waste management, including waste generation, collection, transportation, processing and disposal, as well as biomining and bioremediation of legacy waste dump sites.
- Registration and authorisation of **waste processing facilities + bulk waste generators** with local bodies and State Pollution Control Boards or Pollution Control Committees shall be carried out online through the portal developed by the CPCB.
- Submission of reports by solid waste processing facilities shall also be undertaken online through the portal, **replacing multi-step physical reporting**. The rules mandate **audits** of all waste processing facilities. Audit reports are required to be uploaded on the centralised online portal.

Form – III [see Chapter II, rule 7(1)(c) and Chapter IV, rule 20(1)] Format of annual report to be submitted by the operator of facility to the local body - Page 125-131

Form – IV [see, Chapter IV, rule 20(2) and Chapter V, rule 40(2)(xv)] Format for annual report on solid waste management to be submitted by the local body – Page 131-140

Readiness tests to track the local accountability at local level

A frequent review meeting at the leadership of Municipal Commissioner/ Dy. Commissioner/ HOD/ Chief Officer should check:

Test 1: Waste segregation

What is the target to achieve at least 90% of households level segregation? Do the households consistently handing over segregated waste? What are the key challenges?

Test 2: Waste processing

Can we demonstrate that all collected waste is scientifically processed and that only inert rejects go to landfill?

Test 3: Data

Do we have systems to generate reliable, auditable data on waste generation, collection, recovery, recycling, treatment, and disposal?

Way forward: Making cities SWM Rules 2026 complaint ready...

The Rules shift the focus from infrastructure creation to measurable outcomes. Compliance will increasingly depend on verifiable indicators rather than declarations.

Cities should develop 100 Days Roadmap

- Assess current compliance gaps with respect to SLBs
- Prepare city SWM action plan.
- Map all bulk waste generators.
- Strengthen source segregation campaigns.
- Upgrade collection and transport systems.
- Expand MRF and wet waste processing facilities.
- Establish digital monitoring systems.
- Enforce compliance through phased implementation.

Date	Activity
30 June Every Year	Annual Returns by ULBs, BWGs, RDF users, landfill operators and processors
31 December	Audit Reports uploaded on CPCB Portal
Within 6 Months of Rule Notification (by 1 Oct 2026)	CPCB to operationalize centralized online portal and develop standards for WTE and CBG plants
By September 30, 2026	States to prepare and upload State SWM Policy & Strategy

Way forward: Making cities SWM Rules 2026 complaint ready...

Three messages for municipal leadership

- **Source segregation is the foundation for clean cities.**
Without segregation, no downstream system works.
- **Waste is a resource and not a liability** - Compost, recyclables and RDF create value. Need to innovate in process and find upward linkages
- **Municipal leadership is a key to success.** Technology and infrastructure matter, but implementation depends on governance and citizen engagement.

The success of implementing the SWM Rules 2026 will not be measured by the amount of waste collected by local government, but by the amount of waste reduce, recovered and prevented from reaching open dumping or landfills.

THANK YOU

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About us

The Center for Water and Sanitation (CWAS) is a part of CEPT Research and Development Foundation (CRDF) at CEPT University. CWAS undertakes action-research, implementation support, capacity building and advocacy in the field of urban water and sanitation. Acting as a thought catalyst and facilitator, CWAS works closely with all levels of governments - national, state and local to support them in delivering water and sanitation services in an efficient, effective and equitable manner.

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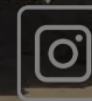
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Initiatives by various local bodies for decentralized collection and transportation

Decentralised collection and transportation model of Ambikapur



Segregation at Source by SHGs



Tricycle for collection driven by women



Tertiary segregation center at sanitation park



Segregation at SLRM center

- The city adopted a decentralized, community-driven C&T system
- 17 wards managed by women self-help groups (SHGs)

Introducing Zero Waste Management (ZWM) units to reduce load on centralized systems



WASTE TRANSPORTATION



COMPOSTING



WASTE SEGREGATION



DRY WASTE STORAGE

- Zero Waste Management (ZWM) units were introduced in the town
- **Rollout of 9 ZWM units** (zone-wise) maintained by local SHGs / federations for neighbourhood segregation, composting, and dry-waste storage.
- **Small biogas units & shredders** (procurement under SFC grants)

Vermi Compost Plant for wet waste processing



- GMC has converted a former dumpsite into a local vermicomposting facility that processes organic waste near its source,
- ensures high-quality compost through well-designed infrastructure and O&M practices, and creates a closed local loop by using and selling the compost within the city

Initiatives of processing waste and converting waste to resource

Saswad processing its wet waste and utilizing as a compost generating monthly 4 lakh revenue



- Material is settled up for windrow composting
- Bioculture sprayed on windrows for effectively reducing waste volume
- Re-shredding after 30 days to produce fine compost ready for sale

Pune's MRF-RDF Model – Waste Pickers Driving Decentralized Resource Recovery



- PMC, in partnership with SWaCH Cooperative developed a decentralized network of MRFs across the city.
- Waste pickers collect dry waste door-to-door, sort recyclables for sale, and send the combustible fraction to RDF units, which supply cement kilns as fuel.

Khedbrama's Solid Waste Processing Plant



- MoU with various industries as forward linkages to segregated dry waste (particularly HDPE, pallets and more)

Good Practices in Plastic Waste Management

Eco Bricks from Plastic Waste Bhavnagar Municipal Corporation



- Citizens were asked to fill one-liter PET bottles with around 350 grams or more of non-recyclable plastic waste
- Paid Rs. 10 for every three such filled bottles,
- Implemented in collaboration with schools.
- 14 tons of plastic waste was used in developing a garden.

Eliminating Single-Use Plastic: Chhattisgarh's Innovative Steps



- Ambikapur's innovative approaches such as the Bartan Bank and Jhola Bank for eco-friendly alternatives to single use plastic
- Bartan Bank initiative - enables residents to rent steel utensils, under the 'ask-use-wash-return' model, at a minimal cost for community gatherings, marriages, and other social functions.

Plastic Waste Recycling in Itarsi, Madhya Pradesh



- Pioneering initiative to manage plastic waste while generating economic and environmental benefits.
- Converts plastic waste into usable items
- Converted into products such as benches, chairs, and paver blocks.
- These recycled plastic items are installed in public spaces like parks and temples.
- A recycled plastic bench costs INR 4,500 compared to INR 8,000 for a cement bench.